PART III · EXPRESSION · 4

# The pedals

Most pianos have three pedals. The right one, the **sustain pedal**, lifts every damper off the strings, so notes keep ringing after your fingers let go. The left one makes the sound softer.

THE SECRET

**Play first, then change the pedal: up and straight down again.**




*Right pedal: the notes keep ringing*

| PEDAL | NAME AND SIGN | WHAT IT DOES |
|---|---|---|
| **left** | soft pedal: *una corda*, written *u.c.* | a softer, gentler sound; lift it at *t.c.* (*tre corde*) |
| **middle** | *sostenuto* *Extra* | holds only the notes already down (on many uprights: a practice mute) |
| **right** | sustain (damper) pedal: *Ped.* | every note keeps ringing until you lift it |

## Writing the sustain pedal

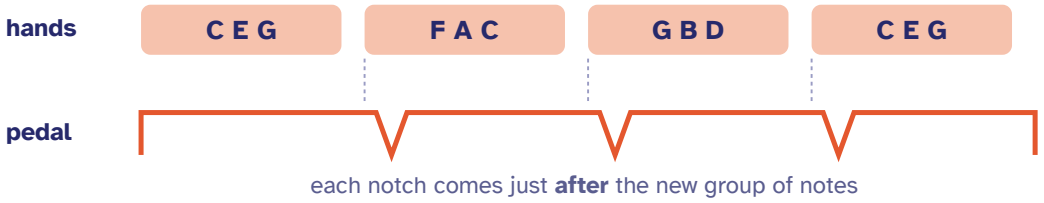



THE RULE

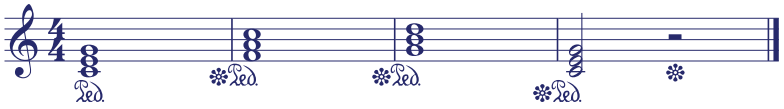
**Heel on the floor, press with the ball of your foot. Play first, then pedal: new notes, then up and straight down again.**

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## Changing the pedal




each notch comes just **after** the new group of notes



A chord is three or more notes played together. The ✻Ped. sits under each new chord: play it first, then change straight away.
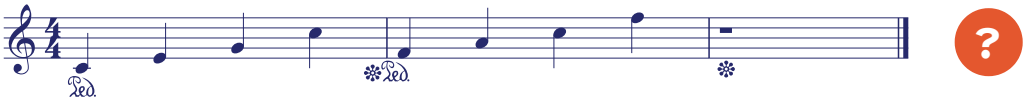
EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

### Half pedal and the middle pedal

**Half pedal:** lift the pedal only part of the way, to clear some of the sound but not all. **Sostenuto** (the middle pedal on grand pianos): press it while notes are held, and only those notes keep ringing.

EXAMPLE 1

**Where does the pedal go down, and where does it come up?**
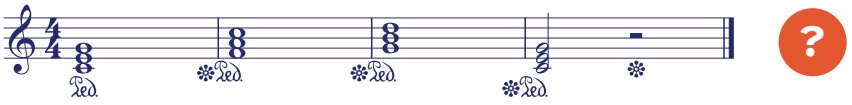


1. **Find Ped.** under the first C.
2. **Find the next sign:** a star with Ped.
3. **Find the last star.**

Down on the first C, **changed** at the first F (up and down again), and up at the end: each bar rings as one sound.

EXAMPLE 2

**Why change at every new chord?**



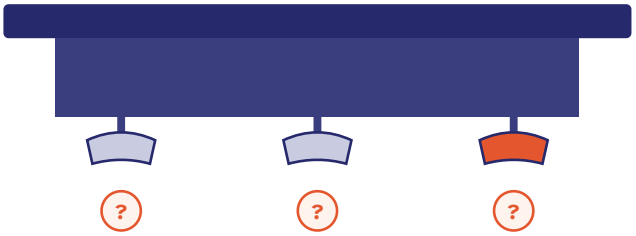
1. **Hold the pedal** from C-E-G into F-A-C. What do you hear?
2. **Now change** just after the F.
3. **Compare** the two.

Without a change, the two groups **blur** into a muddle. Change on each new chord: clean, and still joined.

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EXAMPLE 3

### Which pedal?




1 **Ped.**: which foot pedal? 2 **u.c.**: which one? 3 **t.c.**: what do you do?

Ped. is the **right** pedal; *u.c.* the **left** one; *t.c.* means let the left pedal up.

GAME
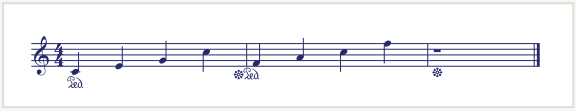
### Up or down?

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ped. | * | u.c. | t.c. |

Which pedal, and up or down?

Answer: 1 right pedal down · 2 right pedal up · 3 left pedal down · 4 left pedal up.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



### Hear the ringing.

Play C, E and G together, press the right pedal and take your hands off: the chord keeps sounding. Lift the pedal: silence.

HOW TO

### Practise the pedal change

1. **Without playing**, say “play, up-down” and move your foot on “up-down”.
2. **Play C-E-G, then F-A-C, then G-B-D**, slowly. Change just after each one.
3. **Listen** for a clean change with no gap of silence.

THINK OF IT The sustain pedal holds a door open: every note that walks in stays in the room until you let the door shut.

TRAP

- × Lifting the pedal before the new notes: a gap of silence. Play first, then change.
- × Keeping the pedal down through a new chord: muddy.

SEE ALSO
Touch p. 75 · Chords p. 106

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Pedal